

Academic writing. A concise manual for students of the faculty PPW

This document can be used as a checklist for students who have to complete a writing task. It contains an overview of the evaluation criteria that are used by many lecturers. Below each criterion you can find more information and a number of useful tips. The advice that is given was based on the following sources.

- Blanpain, K. (2006). *Academic Writing in the Humanities and Social Sciences: A Resource for Researchers*. Leuven, Belgium: Acco.
- Hannay, M., & Lachlan Mackenzie J. (2002). *Effective writing in English: a sourcebook*. Bussum, Netherlands: Coutinho.
- Bailey, S. (2003). *Academic Writing: A Practical Guide for Students*. New York, USA: Routledge.
- Swan, M. (2005). *Practical English Usage*. Oxford, England: Oxford University Press.

General tips

- ✓ Before you start writing, make a scheme of all the elements that you want to discuss in your paper/report.
- ✓ Keep in mind your purpose and audience. Each text genre requires a specific writing style.
- ✓ Use the *APA Student Guide 2014*:
<http://www.lethbridgecollege.ca/sites/default/files/apaguide.pdf>
- ✓ Correct your work, not only digitally, but also on paper. It is often easier to spot mistakes on a printout.
- ✓ Put your text aside for a while and reread it critically after a couple of days.
- ✓ Do you have difficulties applying a number of spelling or grammar rules? Ask a friend or family member to reread your paper to reduce the number of mistakes.
- ✓ Useful websites:
<https://ilt.kuleuven.be/practise/index.php>
<http://www.oxforddictionaries.com/grammar/>
<http://dictionary.cambridge.org/>
- ✓ Use the **Academic Writing Assistant** (https://ilt.kuleuven.be/schrijfhulp_eng/) to check:

Interfacultair Instituut voor Levende Talen

Text review | Text enrichment

Academic Writing Assistant

Welcome to the **Academic Writing Assistant**, a writing tool designed to help students and researchers write academic texts. The tool comprises two components.

- **Text review**
This component offers advice on common language issues, coherence and cohesion, and stylistic matters. For each of these aspects, the writing tool will highlight **possible** problems in your text. As comments are generated automatically, not all the elements which are highlighted are necessarily wrong or relevant to your text. Conversely, the tool only focuses on a limited number of aspects, so some mistakes may not be indicated.
- **Text enrichment**
This component provides information on specific **words and word combinations** (e.g., to carry out / conduct research) as well as on the **contexts** in which they appear.

Some features of the Academic Writing Assistant still need to be fine-tuned. We therefore welcome your **feedback and suggestions** for improving the tool.

To get started, paste your text in the box below and click one of the buttons in the menu.

[SOURCES] - [HELP]
[GIVE FEEDBACK]

• language issues

• coherence and cohesion: sentence and paragraph length, repeated words...

• style: personal and informal language

Specific tips

A. Macrostructure.....	2
B. Microstructure.....	3
C. Style and register.....	4
D. References.....	6
E. Spelling and punctuation.....	6
F. Grammar: at word level	8
G. Grammar: syntax.....	10
H. Tables, figures and graphs.....	12
I. Distribution of content in several sections	12

A. Macrostructure

Objective: the paper has an appropriate title, a coherent structure, and contains all the required elements. As a whole the paper is aptly divided into chapters and paragraphs. In addition, its layout is well-organised.

1. Title

- ✓ A good title is not too long, but still as specific as possible. Make sure that the title covers all that is dealt with in the paper and includes important key words.
- ✓ It is highly plausible that you will have to adjust your title in the course of your writing process.

2. Table of contents

- ✓ Make sure that your table of contents is complete and that the titles correspond to the ones you have used in the text. Tip: in text processing programs the table of contents can often be generated automatically.
- ✓ On the one hand, table of contents that include subdivisions are usually clearer. On the other hand, however, too many subdivisions can bring about a disorganised look. Include subdivisions up to the fourth level (e.g. 2.1.1.1). Do not include further levels, especially not when you are writing a short paper.
- ✓ If the writing assignment is not longer than a few pages, a table of contents is usually unnecessary. Always follow the guidelines provided by the lecturer.

3. (Sub)divisions into chapters and paragraphs

Your paper will have a clearer and more logical structure when you apply an appropriate and uniform division into chapters and paragraphs. The amount of divisions and subdivisions depends on the length of the paper.

- ✓ A *chapter* starts with an introduction that clarifies the internal structure of the chapter.
- ✓ A chapter is built up of *paragraphs*. These usually consist of five to fifteen sentences. An introduction could, for instance, count one or more paragraphs.
- ✓ A *paragraph* is a group of sentences unified by a topic or idea. It usually starts with a clear topic sentence which expresses the main point made in the paragraph.

4. Key elements

- ✓ Most papers contain the following elements: introduction (includes research question), materials and methods, results, discussion and conclusions, references.
- ✓ In short writing tasks the following structure is used: introduction – body – conclusion.
- ✓ A lot of lecturers provide guidelines referring to the key elements that need to be included in each writing task. Always follow those guidelines.

5. Layout

- ✓ When you distribute the text evenly between the margins a page looks more polished. To achieve this result you have to justify the text.
- ✓ The division into paragraphs is clearly visible when you add an indentation to the first line of the paragraph (= APA norm).

B. Microstructure

Objective: each paragraph is a coherent whole containing a topic sentence and supporting arguments. The coherence of each paragraph is improved by signalling logical connections (linking words, enumeration...). Each chapter consists of a logical sequence of paragraphs.

1. Paragraph coherence and sequence

- ✓ Adding a clear topic sentence to each paragraph creates coherence. This is usually, though not necessarily, the first sentence.
- ✓ Make sure that the paragraph stays within the scope of the topic sentence.
- ✓ Organise paragraphs carefully to avoid moving back and forth between elements.
- ✓ Put yourself in the reader's position and create a sequence that is logical and easy to follow.

2. Signalling logical connections

- ✓ When logical connections are specified, it is easier for the reader to see how one sentence/paragraph relates to another.
- ✓ There are a number of tools that you can use to improve coherence:
 - i. Linking words

Function	Linking word
Highlighting a topic	with regard to / in this respect / concerning
Expressing contrast	however / although / while / in contrast
Indicating result and logical consequence	as a result / consequently / therefore / thus
Adding information	moreover / furthermore / in addition / also
Giving a parallel or alternative	in other words / for instance
Indicating sequence	subsequently / next / finally

! *However* (= sentence adverb) ↔ *although* (= subordinating conjunction)

- This research does not address the issue of causality. *However*, these findings do add one more dimension to a growing body of literature that ...

- *Although* this research does not address the issue of causality, these findings do provide evidence of ...

! *In contrast* (= on the other hand) ↔ *on the contrary* (= the opposite is true)

- ! *Therefore* (= *for that reason*) ≠ *for this purpose/to this end*
- Most countries have little control over the prices at which they sell their commodity exports. *Therefore*, devaluations are generally expected ...
- * A variety of practical tools currently available *therefore* are discussed.
 - > tools currently available *for this purpose* ...
- We analyse the interactions between these variables. * *Therefore*, two different statistical techniques are used in sequence.
 - > *To this end*, two different statistical techniques are used in sequence.

ii. Enumeration (first, second...)

- ! Both *first* and *firstly* can be used, but be consistent. If you use *firstly*, then you should use *secondly*.
- ! Try not to use these linking words to start a paragraph.

3. Repetition

- ✓ Try to avoid needless repetition. Rephrase sentences and restructure paragraphs to avoid this.

Don'ts	Dos
The European Community established the European Monetary System in 1978. The establishment of the monetary system took place during a European summit in Bremen and the system was put into operation a year after this summit .	The European Monetary System (EMS) was established by the European Community in 1978 during a European summit in Bremen and was put into operation a year later.

- ✓ Repetition can be useful to avoid confusion. At times precision is more important than variety (in chapters such as methods, results, discussion). Furthermore, repetition is a useful tool to formulate a clear contrast.

Don'ts	Dos
A company which produces environment-friendly products is not necessarily as 'clean' as an organisation which operates an ecologically responsible means of production.	A company which produces environment-friendly products is not necessarily as 'clean' as a company which operates an environmental-friendly means of production.

C. **Style and register**

Objective: the paper adopts an academic and/or scientific writing style that is appropriate for the genre and the audience.

1. Formal language

- ✓ Use longer and more complex sentences but do not overdo it.
- ✓ Avoid informal expressions (~~by the way, a bit...~~). Formal alternatives: incidentally, slightly...

- ✓ Do not use contractions (~~she's~~ → she is).

2. Use of "I"

- ✓ Academic writing is typically depersonalised, i.e. usually you do not use "I".
- ✓ Exceptions: you should not always shy away from using "I". For instance, if you are asked to write an opinion piece, a personal style is appropriate. In some research fields it can even be a requirement.
- ✓ If you are writing a text in which it is best not to use "I", these alternatives can be more appropriate:
 - Passive constructions:
*In this study, the same method of analysis **has been adopted**.*
 - It is ... structures:
It is worth noting / It is clear / It is important to note that ...
 - Sentence adverbs:
Clearly / Unfortunately / Interestingly / ...

Don'ts	Dos
In the following, I will argue that there is a need for alternative punishments.	The following will argue that there is a need for alternative punishments.
We then asked the students to compare two versions of the same texts.	The students were then asked to compare two versions of the same text.
I think the potential mismatch is particularly important in ...	The potential mismatch is particularly important in ...
I find it surprising that these reasons were completely neglected.	Surprisingly , these reasons were completely neglected. OR It is surprising that these reasons were completely neglected.

3. Avoid generalisations

- ✓ Limit and qualify your claims to make your writing more precise and objective. Do not use sweeping generalisations.
- ✓ Use the following constructions:
it is likely that / it could, might, may / probably / to a certain extent / ...

Don'ts	Dos
It is obvious that this supports our hypothesis.	This seems to lend support to our hypothesis.
The respondents judged that ...	A majority of the respondents judged that...
This phenomenon is visible everywhere .	This phenomenon is visible in most parts of the world.

4. Avoid archaic or sloppy language and redundancy

- ✓ Your text will not become more "academic" when you use a great number of difficult words and overly complex structures. This only leads to a text that is more difficult to read.
- ✓ Do not repeat information when it is not necessary for comprehension.
- ✓ Examples of archaic language: hereupon, hither, therewith, erelong, thenceforth, whence...

Don'ts	Dos
A lie can improve one's status . A very famous lie which had to do with the improvement of status was made up by a man called Carl Schwietert.	A lie can improve one's status. One very famous example is due to a man called Carl Schwietert.
Hobson is the only person whom we have not interviewed. (= outdated)	Hobson is the only person who was not interviewed.
This is the basic background on which he bases his thinking on popular music.	He based his thinking on popular music on the aforementioned theories .

D. References

Objective: the student cites sources when necessary and does not commit plagiarism. The bibliography is complete and conforms to the APA style.

1. When to refer to a source?

When you use someone else's work in your paper (by citing or paraphrasing), you always have to refer to the source. Do this while you are writing to ensure that you are not committing plagiarism. If you have to insert all the references later on you are more likely to forget a number of them.

- ✓ Interesting resources: <http://www.kuleuven.be/plagiarism/index.html>

2. Be complete

- ✓ Make sure that every in-text citation can be found in your reference list (bibliography).
- ✓ Check whether each source in your bibliography has a reference in the text.

3. Accuracy

At the Faculty of Psychology and Educational Sciences all students are expected to adopt the APA style of referencing (unless stated otherwise).

- ✓ Tip: use the source below.
American Psychological Association (Ed.). (2010-2013). *Publication manual of the American Psychological Association*. Washington, DC: American Psychological Association.

E. Spelling and punctuation

Objective: the paper is written in standard English and conforms to spelling and punctuation rules.

1. Spelling

- ✓ Choose between British and American spelling. Be consistent. When in doubt consult a dictionary: <http://www.oxforddictionaries.com/> , <http://www.ldoceonline.com/> , <http://dictionary.cambridge.org/>

British spelling	American spelling
endings in –ise/-yse (<i>analyse, organise, criticise</i>)	endings in –ize/-yze (<i>analyze, organize, criticize</i>)
endings in –our (<i>colour, favour</i>)	endings in –or (<i>color, favor</i>)
programme (only computer programs)	program
practice (noun) / practise (verb)	practice (noun + verb)
modelled	modeled
centre	center

- ✓ Some spelling rules in English differ from those in Dutch. Below you can find a few examples. When in doubt check a grammar reference.

Topic	Dutch	English
Plurals	nouns ending in a vowel: + 's e.g.: ski's, foto's	noun + s e.g.: skis, photos
Capitals	compounds relating to holidays: no capital e.g.: kerstvakantie	capitals always remain e.g.: Christmas holidays

- ✓ It is very likely that a few typographical errors can still be found in a text. Too many of these errors, however, give an impression of negligence.
- ✓ Watch out for then vs. than
Then = refers to time (e.g.: First, the participants [...]. Then they were asked to [...].)
Than = used in a comparison or in expressions such as *other than*, *rather than* (e.g.: Group A showed more signs of improvement than group B.)

2. Abbreviations

- ✓ Make sure to only use accepted abbreviations.
- ✓ If you want to abbreviate a specific word, first write down the phrase in full followed by the abbreviation between brackets. Afterwards you can use that abbreviation.
- ✓ Check the spelling of the abbreviation in a dictionary (capital letters, full stops).

3. Numbers (= in APA style)

- ✓ Write numbers in full at the beginning of a sentence. Numbers from one to ten are written in full when they do not represent precise measurements (e.g.: eight items, nine...).
- ✓ Watch out: when you are discussing temperature, weight, years... you should not write the numbers in full (e.g.: 5,1 grams).
- ✓ Follow the rules above, but avoid strange combinations of words and numbers. Make sure that you are consistent within the same sentence/paragraph.

4. Punctuation

- ✓ Use punctuation properly: do not overuse it and do not drop it when it is necessary.
- ✓ Make sure that you use the appropriate punctuation mark.
- ✓ Tip: <http://www.oxforddictionaries.com/words/punctuation>
- ✓ Longer sentences are common in formal writing, but do not exaggerate. Use full stops on a regular basis.

F. Grammar: at word level

Objective: the paper is devoid of grammatical errors (e.g. incorrect conjugations, inflections...).

For a more exhaustive look at grammar, see Blanpain (2006, Part 3, Unit 10).

1. Verb conjugation

Form:

Remember that there are a number of irregular verbs (e.g.: to be, to send, to grow...). You can find more information about the conjugation of regular and irregular verbs on the following webpage:

<http://www.oxforddictionaries.com/words/regular-and-irregular-verbs>.

Don'ts	Dos
He sended	He sent
He applied	He applied
He prefered	He preferred

2. Passive voice

In general do not overuse passive constructions. Nevertheless, these constructions can be used for a number of purposes:

- ✓ When the agent (= the person doing the action) is not the theme of the sentence (e.g. in the methodology section).
- ✓ When it is difficult to specify the agent.
- ✓ To soften criticism.

3. Time indications

- ✓ *During* = refers to a period when something happened
- ✓ *For* = refers to duration (how long something lasted)
- ✓ *Since* = refers to the starting point (used with present perfect)

4. Adverb position

Adverbs are used to qualify a sentence, a verb, an adjective or another adverb. They express manner, time, place or degree. Below you can see where different adverbs are positioned within a sentence.

- ✓ Sentence adverbs: usually at the start of the sentence
Unfortunately, it has several shortcomings.
- ✓ Mid-position adverbs: most adverbs fall under this category. You place the adverb before the main verb, after to be or after the auxiliary verb.
 - *This also shows the importance of ...* (before the main verb)
 - *This is clearly an advantage.* (after to be)
 - *The contrary may indeed be happening.* (after the auxiliary verb)

5. Relative clauses: that, who or which?

A relative clause is a part of a sentence that is introduced by a relative pronoun (e.g.: who, that, which). Make sure that you use the appropriate relative pronoun in each context.

First of all, you need to distinguish between a restrictive and non-restrictive relative clause. A relative clause is restrictive when you need the information that is given to understand the sentence. The opposite is true for a non-restrictive clause.

e.g.: *The woman who is wearing a blue scarf is looking at me.* (= restrictive, no commas)

My wife, who is wearing a blue scarf, is looking at me. (= non-restrictive, commas)

Secondly, you need to look at the person/thing that you are referring to:

- ✓ Restrictive clause: when you refer to people: who/that
 when you refer to things: that/which
- ✓ Non-restrictive clause: when you refer to people: who
 when you refer to things: which

6. Articles

- ✓ All nouns need an article (a/an/the) when used in the singular, unless they are uncountable.
 - *countable* nouns: refer to something that can be counted, e.g.: cat, woman, country
 - *uncountable* nouns: a smaller number of nouns that do not refer to things that can be counted, e.g.: rain, information, water, equipment
- > Uncountable nouns are not used with a/an.

- ✓ A / an?
 - First letter of the word is pronounced as a vowel: an
 - First letter of the word is pronounced as a consonant: a

A	An
a ewe	an early-warning system
a one-off arrangement	an only child
a united front	an understandable mistake
a happy thought	an hour

- ✓ When to use "the"?
 - superlatives (the *most* famous)
 - time periods (the 1980s)
 - unique things (the moon)
 - specified things (the knowledge of most employees)
- ✓ When do you not use "the"?
 - names of countries, except for the UK and the US (+ a few others)
 - abstract nouns (poverty, happiness)

7. Prepositions

In English, a great deal of words are followed by fixed prepositions. Here a number of commonly used phrases are listed.

research	in (+ particular field of study)
	on (+ particular subject)
depending	on
react	to
consist	of
derive	from
similar	to
based	on
gain insight	into

G. Grammar: syntax

Objective: the paper is easy to read thanks to appropriate sentence constructions and length.
Verb tenses are used consistently.

1. Illogical sentences

- ✓ Avoid illogical sentences. Sentences can be illogical due to poor word choice, an illogical word order, mental leaps, or missing elements.
- ✓ Remember that each sentence needs a subject and main verb.

Don'ts	Dos
<i>Where Napoleon spent the rest of his days</i> was that.	That was <i>were</i> <i>Napoleon spent the rest of his days</i> .
He was just too confused. <i>And called</i> me 18 times.	<i>He</i> was just too confused and <i>called</i> me 18 times.
<i>An underdeveloped country, in which many are undereducated.</i> Such countries must be helped as much as possible.	<i>In underdeveloped countries many people are undereducated.</i> Such countries must be helped as much as possible.

- ✓ Watch out for dangling participles (for a definition of dangling participles see: <http://blog.oxforddictionaries.com/2011/09/participles-how-not-to-dangle/>).

Tip: make sure that the participle has a clear subject. Have a look at the example below.

Don'ts	Dos
Having acknowledged the importance of this issue , the accessibility of services became a hot topic in Europe.	After <u>being</u> acknowledged as an important issue, <u>the accessibility of services</u> became a hot topic in Europe.

How to discover dangling participles:

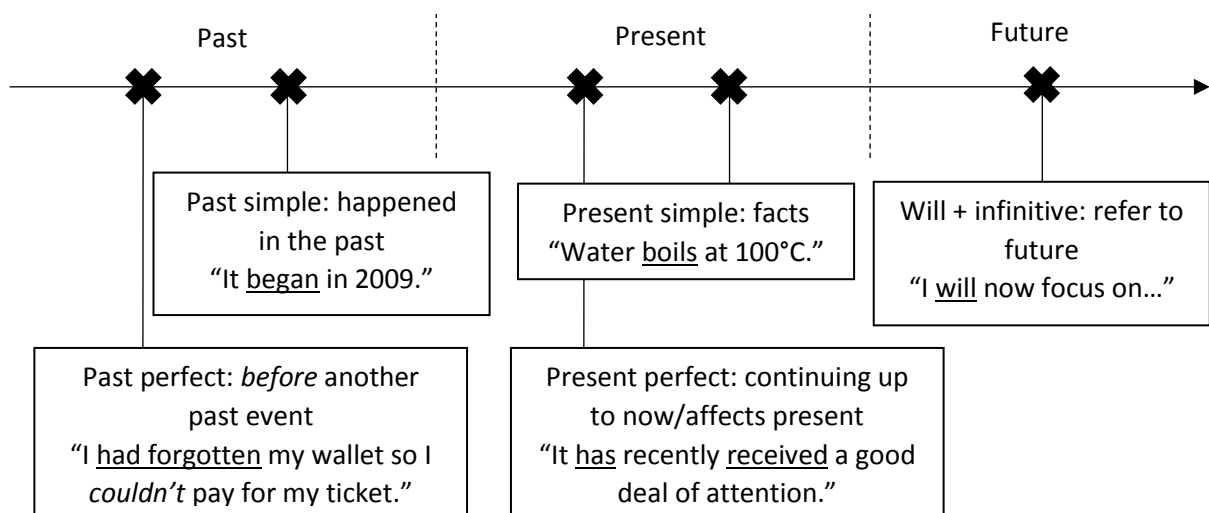
- Question: what is the subject of the participle?
- Expected answer: the subject of the main clause.

- If this is not the case, it is a dangling participle.
- In example:
 - Who acknowledged the importance of this issue?
 - Subject main clause: “the accessibility of services”
 - This is not the correct answer so it is a dangling participle.

2. Verb conjugation

Tense and aspect:

In English, as in Dutch, there are three main tenses: the past, the present and the future. These three tenses can be used in their simple, continuous or perfect form (= aspect). The timeline below demonstrates when to use which tense in a simplistic way. Only the tenses that are most relevant within the context of academic writing are included.



3. Sentence length

- ✓ Both short and long sentences can serve their purpose in a paper. Make sure that you use them appropriately. Short sentences are mostly used to make messages stand out or to round off an argument.
- ✓ Try to vary in sentence length. Do not use too many long/short sentences after one another.
- ✓ The easiest way to determine whether a sentence is too long is to read it out loud. If you have to reread the sentence to understand what it is about, chances are the sentence is too long.

Don'ts	Dos
New drugs and a vaccine alone are not enough to fight malaria. They have to be combined with improved health-care facilities, for example spraying campaigns, neighbourhood clean-ups to eliminate breeding places for the mosquito and better environmental management including biological controls, such as ...	New drugs and a vaccine alone are not enough to fight malaria. They have to be combined with improved health-care facilities, for example spraying campaigns, and neighbourhood clean-ups to eliminate breeding places for the mosquito. Moreover , there is a need for better environmental management, including biological controls, such as ...

H. Tables, figures and graphs

Objective: tables, figures and/or graphs are presented in an organised manner and they constitute an added value. Each table, figure and/or graph is numbered, has a title and is discussed in the paper (with references).

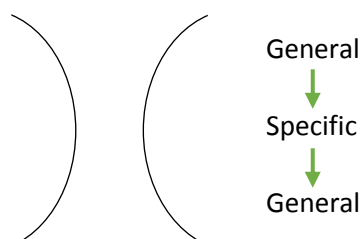
1. Number and title
 - ✓ All visual aids need to be numbered sequentially with Arabic numbers (e.g. 1, 2, 3...). Do not use suffix letters (e.g. 1a, 1b, 1c).
 - ✓ Each table must have a clear and concise title.
2. Coherent, simple, relevant
 - ✓ Choose a simple and straightforward layout.
 - ✓ Make sure that the tables, figures and graphs that you include are necessary to understand your findings. Not all visual representations are relevant. You should not use them as page fillers.
3. Discussion
 - ✓ You need to refer to tables, figures and graphs in the text. Do not simply enumerate statistics. Analyse and interpret the information that can be derived from the visual representations.
 - ✓ At the same time you need to ensure that the tables, figures and graphs are intelligible for a reader without having to read the text.

I. Distribution of content in several sections

This criterion supersedes language and form. It has been included nonetheless since content and form can never be fully separated.

The content of each component of a writing assignment is dependent on the topic and nature of the assignment. However, there are a number of general components that are applicable to most writing tasks.

- ✓ A proper *introduction* frames the research question. It elaborates on the relevance of your research, gives information about previous research and identifies a problem or gap. A clear aim is formulated. Furthermore, the structure of the paper is outlined.
- ✓ The description of *methodology* aims to explain in detail how the study was conducted. Include the number of participants/samples, materials/instruments, procedure... Do not forget to include why you opted for this particular approach. Try to use the funnel model below to organise your writing. Start with the general context before zooming in on specifics. Afterwards go back to the big picture.



- ✓ Afterwards the *results* of your study should be described objectively. The discussion and interpretation of these results follows later on. Make sure that tables and graphs are discussed properly in the text and that you do not simply enumerate statistics.
- ✓ In the *discussion and conclusion* section the results are interpreted within the context of existing research. No new information can be added at this point apart from suggestions for further research. The following questions can help you when writing this section: what was analysed and what were the main findings? How can these results be interpreted? What were the limitations of your study?